

Meloni Cuts the Hard Right a Path to Power

From Outcast to Avatar
of Post-Fascist Italy

By ROGER COHEN

ROME — Giorgia Meloni, daughter of the extreme right, likes to set records. As she settles into an armchair opposite a painting of rustic revelry inspired by Titian, she reflects on the secret of the political success that will soon make her the longest continually serving prime minister in the history of the Italian Republic.

“I am a person who imposes rules on herself,” she says in a rare interview. “The first rule is that I never say something I don’t think. There is no way to get me to say something I don’t believe — my brain short-circuits.”

She smiles, as if to say it’s that simple, but of course it is not. She has remained something of an enigma, a tightly controlled one, as she has journeyed from post-Fascist roots to a pivotal place in the European politics she is changing.

Ms. Meloni has chosen to meet in a lounge adjacent to her Rome office. She is gracious to a fault. In such moments it is hard to recall the way she may roll her eyes and stare daggers when angry, as she has been of late with President Trump, her ideological ally, and Pedro Sánchez, the left-wing Spanish prime minister, an ideological foe.

“I think people see the difference,” says Ms. Meloni, who has been in office for almost four years, about four times the post-war Italian average. “They know if something’s untrue, false — and I believe that’s the biggest mistake a politician can make.”

Truth is not exactly the political currency of this age, but Ms. Meloni has always marched to her own drum. The effect has been transformative. “Melonization,” or the numbing of horrifying history, has entered the lexicon.

It denotes the process Ms. Meloni now personifies that allows a post-Fascist party, in this case her Brothers of Italy, to shed the threat of violent authoritarianism and gain acceptance in the mainstream through pragmatic conservatism, or at least its appearance.

“I think what got me here” — to her office at Palazzo Chigi — “was the courage to stand on the uncomfortable side of history,” Ms. Meloni says, speaking Italian. “To



DAVIDE MONTELEONE FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

‘It’s evident that with Donald Trump, I believed things would be easier, given our convergence on immigration and woke culture. Things have turned out otherwise.’

GIORGIA MELONI, the Italian prime minister, on her strained relationship with President Trump.

opt to be against the current.”

Courage is by some distance her favorite word.

With Marine Le Pen, of the once-outcast French far right, a strong candidate in next year’s presidential election, and the

hard-right Alternative for Germany, or AfD, leading polls in that country, the Meloni effect is about to be tested at the core of postwar European integration.

If Fascism in Italy, land of its birth, can be made to seem re-

mote, even irrelevant to political success, so too perhaps can the Holocaust in Germany and the collaborationist wartime Vichy regime in France. It was Vichy’s antisemitic nationalism that in-

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NEWS ANALYSIS

Carney Takes Risky Stand With Trump

Defiance in Face of U.S. Trade Threats

By MATINA STEVIS-GRIDNEFF

TORONTO — On Friday night, Prime Minister Mark Carney of Canada did something that few other world leaders before him have dared to do.

After days of intense trade negotiations with the United States, with less than an hour to go on a midnight deadline for a new round of tariffs from the Trump administration, Mr. Carney instructed his negotiators to walk away.

Then, he announced that once 50 percent tariffs came into effect on \$20 billion worth of Canadian goods, he would order retaliatory tariffs on the United States “dollar for dollar.”

Then on Saturday, in a lengthy televised address to Canadians, Mr. Carney brought fighting words to Canada’s act of defiance.

“Last spring, I warned that America is trying to break us so that they can own us. And I promised: ‘That will never, ever happen.’ We are keeping that promise,” Mr. Carney said somberly, before reporters in Ottawa.

“Canada is becoming stronger and less dependent on America. We are already giving ourselves more than they can take away. And we are just getting started,” he added.

By walking away, Mr. Carney chose a road that no major U.S. ally has taken: With his country’s economy on the line, he stood up to President Trump and refused to accept the administration’s offer of a new trade relationship with tariffs permanently baked in. Britain, the European Union and other major U.S. trading partners have agreed to

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‘AT WAR’ Prime Minister Mark Carney of Canada suspended trade talks with the U.S. despite President Trump’s punishing tariffs. PAGE 10

FAMILY CHAT “The Necessary Conversation,” a podcast and YouTube show, airs out the political disputes straining relationships. PAGE 16

HOW TRUMP ALLY SHAPED POLICY FOR HOMELESS

BILLIONAIRE’S CRUSADE

Cicero Institute Steering G.O.P. Away From ‘Housing First’

By ELLEN BARRY and JASON DePARLE

A team from the Cicero Institute, an upstart think tank, flew to Indiana this year to help make it a crime for the homeless to sleep on the street.

It was their third attempt. Even in the conservative state, previous efforts to ban street camping had failed. Roman Catholic leaders said the measure would hurt the poor, and sheriffs had warned that arrests would crowd the jails.

“We’re Hoosiers — we’re better than that,” a Republican state senator, Ron Alting, said last year, urging a more caring approach.

But much had changed since the group, founded by Joe Lonsdale, a billionaire ally of President Trump’s, had made its initial efforts. Mr. Trump had issued an executive order on homelessness that so fully reflected Cicero’s agenda it was hard to tell where the group stopped and White House policy began.

The sponsor of the Indiana law was fresh from a Cicero conference, Cicero lobbyists worked the bill, and three Cicero analysts testified that the threat of arrests would push homeless people into treatment for mental illness or addiction.

The ban passed just before the legislature adjourned.

With homelessness near record

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Joe Lonsdale

Devices Leave Haitians in Ohio Shackled, and Feeling Shaken

By MIRIAM JORDAN

SPRINGFIELD, Ohio — Before dawn on Wednesday, Jonas Julien waited in the darkness of his Springfield home for his ride to an Immigration and Customs Enforcement office about an hour away.

The 35-year-old Haitian immigrant had completed another grueling 12-hour shift at 3:30 a.m. After a quick bite and shower, he had stretched on the couch to avoid waking his wife and their 2-month-old daughter. But sleep never came.

“I don’t know what awaits me, and I am just exhausted from the worry,” Mr. Julien said after climbing into the back seat of a Toyota Corolla, clutching a folder of immigration documents that included

an active asylum petition and a work permit valid until 2029.

By the time he returned to his wife and daughter about 10 hours later, a clunky black band with a blinking light would be clamped around his left ankle. He would have an order to report back to ICE in a few weeks. And he would be afraid for their future.

Mr. Julien is among hundreds of Haitians in Springfield who have been summoned to ICE offices, according to the Haitian Support Center, a local organization. The group estimates that more than 100 people have been fitted with ankle monitors.

A city of 60,000 between Dayton and Columbus, Springfield has

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NIC COURRY FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

America’s Shrinking Forests

Bigger and hotter wildfires in the West are turning towering woodlands into shrubland. Page 21.

Faded Dreams In Hollywood? Royals Relate.

By NICOLE SPERLING and SHAWN HUBLER

LOS ANGELES — It began with such high hopes.

The Duke and Duchess of Sussex landed in Hollywood in 2020, flush with a multimillion-dollar Netflix deal and a promise that the duo, scorned by the royal family, would make a slew of inspirational programming.

Two years later, “Harry & Meghan” the Netflix six-part docuseries on the couple’s departure from Britain, generated 23.4 million views in its initial release, immediately topping the company’s charts as the most watched ever for the first four days of a documentary. In total, the program has garnered 70 million views since its debut.

Nothing else Prince Harry and his wife, Meghan, ever made for the service — whether it was “Live to Lead,” a seven-episode interview show with world leaders, or “Polo,” a docuseries about the sport — reached such heights.

In 2025, the Netflix deal was not renewed. A similarly lofty agreement at Spotify also fell short of expectations.

And as Americans asked last week why the couple was leaving

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Students Lose Much More Than Grammar Skills When They Use A.I. to Write

By DANA GOLDSTEIN

After years of studying how human beings write, the cognitive psychologist Ronald T. Kellogg concluded that drafting a basic persuasive essay was as mentally taxing as digging a ditch was physically exhausting.

Writing well requires a com-

mand of vocabulary, spelling and grammar. It forces writers to comprehend a subject, to sift through their working memory of that topic, to organize and plan. Writing an essay is so difficult that a person in the throes of it can do hardly anything else — as anyone who has shushed a spouse or child while trying to compose a decent

sentence can attest.

Very few people would volunteer to dig a ditch. Likewise, it is hard — almost impossible, many English teachers will admit — to turn a reluctant writer into an enthusiastic one.

Yet the American education system expects nearly all students to learn how to write an es-

say. It’s little wonder, then, that as soon as a tool arrived promising to lessen the pain, people grabbed it.

Like it or not, artificial intelligence is now firmly embedded in how students produce text. Somewhere between two-thirds and 90 percent of high school and college students are already using A.I. for schoolwork, according to recent

surveys, often requesting help with writing assignments.

A growing number of educators are alarmed, and insist that students should write without A.I. These teachers are returning to handwriting, blue books and proctored, in-class essay tests — all attempts to prevent students from

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INTERNATIONAL 4-15

Present-Day Past Masters

When two British historians began “The Rest Is History,” neither thought it would become the top history podcast in the English-speaking world. PAGE 4

The Dirty-Joke Diplomat

President Trump’s envoy to Belarus says his chummy approach gets results. Critics contend he is giving up too much to an authoritarian leader. PAGE 8

Clues on the Next Pandemic

Scientists say climate change is speeding the spread of new viruses that jump from animals to humans, as Ebola and hantavirus likely did. PAGE 10



SPORTS 24-26

Costly U.S. Open Tickets

Prices for every kind of seat are on the rise, but so too is the tournament’s popularity, as live sporting events become ever more lucrative. PAGE 24

SUNDAY OPINION

Susan Faludi

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SUNDAY STYLES

A Novelist’s Look at Fame

Rachel Cusk’s book “Life of M” has a protagonist who resembles Natalie Portman, bringing a kind of attention the author says she didn’t want. PAGE 5

Confidante at the Pentagon

Jennifer Hegseth’s role as an adviser to her husband, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth, is raising questions. PAGE 1

ARTS & LEISURE

On a Bumpy Road to Britain

A 900-year-old treasure’s journey from France to London required engineering and unorthodox diplomacy. PAGE 8



METROPOLITAN

Aging Nuns on a Mission

As convents are closing all over, these sisters unite to live together in a care center in a New York suburb. PAGE 1

SUNDAY BUSINESS

Silicon Valley Confronts A.I.

Big Tech is trying to dig out of the heap of artificial intelligence slop filling its platforms, but many of the companies trying to manage the low-quality content are also enabling it. PAGE 1

Ahead of the Class: Big Tech

Companies like Google and Microsoft have used their money, and might and their platforms to influence the education supply chain. PAGE 6

